

SEMIOTIC SYMBOLS AND COMMUNICATION: PALM FRONDS IN IWHURUOHNA (IKWERRE) ETHNIC NATIONALITY OF RIVERS STATE

By

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ABSTRACT

In semiotic studies, Charles Sanders Peirce (Founder of Semiotics) identified three subsets of a sign-icon, index and symbol. While an iconic sign deals with the resemblance or lookalikehood of the signifier and signified; indexical sign dwells on a cause and effect relationship between a signifier and signified. However, in a symbolic sign, there is an arbitrary relationship between a signifier and signified and a conventionality blend as cultural contexts play a role in assigning meanings to objects or symbols. The scientific or systematic study of signs and signaling system is semiotics. Therefore, the subject matter or main thrust in semiotic analysis is a sign. The aim of this research is to evaluate the palm frond as a symbolic sign in Ikwerre speaking areas of Rivers State. Iwhuruohna people (Ikwerre) have their aborigines in some Local Government Areas of Rivers State viz: Ikwerre LGA, Port Harcourt City LGA, Obio-Akpor LGA and Emohua LGA. The people refer to themselves as 'Iwhuruohna' due to their historical trace or bond to the ancient Benin Kingdom through their ancestor – "Ihuroha". Although there are some controversial theories of origin of Iwhuruohna ethnicity, this researcher prefers the Ancient Benin theory of origin to the Igbo expansionist theory. This paper adopts the semiotic theory to explain some communicative values of palm fronds in Ikwerre speaking areas of Rivers State.

Key words: Signifier, Signified, Semiotics, Sign, Charles Sanders Peirce, Semiology

Introduction

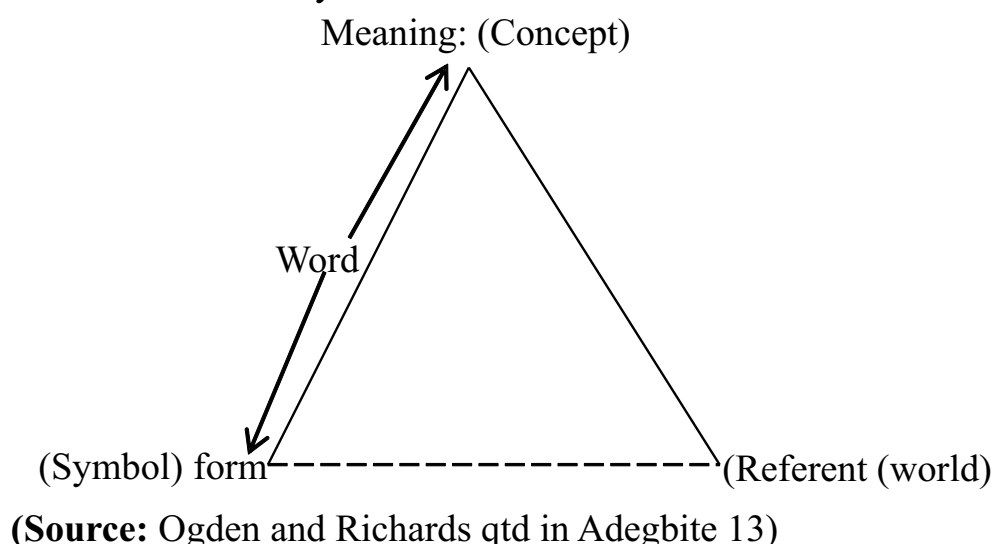
The notion of symbol intended, here, is a subset of a sign as enunciated by Charles Sanders Peirce, who advanced the teachings or research works of the Swiss-Linguist, Ferdinand de Saussure. Ferdinand de Saussure is widely recognised as the founder of modern linguistics. In his *Course in General Linguistics*, he taught in Geneva from 1907 – 11, made known to a broad audience as "*Cours de Linguistique Generale*" (CLG 1916), a book published posthumously under Saussure's name based on his lecture notes – Saussure laid out an approach to language whose premises largely followed principles of the turn of the 20th century revolution in philosophy and methodology of science ("Lecture Notes on Linguistics").

Saussure defined the object of scholarly studies by postulating the features relevant, specifically, for that field as the centre point of anti-positivist critique. Saussure strove to

dichotomise linguistic studies from empiricism by laying out postulates concerning its nature that should stand as guidelines for its scholarly description. He defined “language” (*la langue*), as an internalised system of symbolic units (signs), defined by their intrasystematic relations, in contradistinction to “speech” (*la parole*) as the empirical speech activity. According to Saussure, signs of language are arbitrary, in the sense, that the relation between their physical and symbolic distinction from each other have no grounds but convention (*ibid*).

This Saussurean notion birthed the Referential Theory of meaning which holds that the meaning of any expression is the actual entity or object in the real world to which the expression refers. There is no direct connection and relationship between the expression and the object it stands for, save the thought of the object. This postulation could be, aptly, captured in the signification triangle which encapsulates the essence of the Referential Theory of meaning propounded by Ferdinand de Saussure (Adegbite 13).

Figure 1: Referential Theory



From the diagram above, the linguistic unit (phonemes or lexical items) constitute the symbol while the referent is the real entity in the physical reality the symbols refer to. The thought or concept is the mental information suggested by the symbol and referent. The dotted line (...) at the base of the triangle demonstrated that there is no direct link or relation between the symbol and referent. This representation above cannot account for abstract nouns, phrases, clauses and sentences, polysemous and hyponymous words or items. These limitations weakened this theory of meaning but, however, gave rise to the Mentalist Theory of Meaning.

De Saussure's semiology investigates the nature of signs and laws governing them. Saussure coined semiology as part of his interest in language as a system of signs. The terms

have, generally, been regarded as synonymous, but semiotics is better known, especially, in the English-speaking world (McArthur 835).

By this, it could be deduced that semiology was dominant in the French-speaking areas while semiotics is in the English areas. In another development, semiotics is a comprehensive term or concept than semiology. It covers all other nonverbal communication forms such as clothes, hairstyles, age, class and body language.

Charles Sanders Peirce was born on September 10, 1839, in Cambridge, Massachusetts, and he died on April 19, 1914, in Milford, Pennsylvania. His writing extends from about 1857 until near his death, a period of approximately 57 years. His published works run about 12,000 printed pages and his unpublished manuscripts run about 80,000 hand written pages. The topics on which he wrote have an immense range from mathematics and the physical sciences at one extreme, to economics, psychology, and other social sciences at the other extreme (Source: SEP, Peirce 3).

Peirce remains a noted logician who founded philosophical pragmatism as he defined “semiosis” as an irreducibly triadic process wherein something, as an object, logically, determines or influences something as an interpretation or “interpretant”, itself a sign, thus, leading to further interpretants. The Peircesemiotic paradigm is triadic: sign, object, interpretant as opposed to a dyadic succession tradition of “signified” and “signifier”. The Peircesemiotic model, further, subdivides into such areas as positing the existence of signs that are symbols. Semblances (icons and indices, that is, signs that are such through factual connection to their objects). According to M.H. Abrams and Harpham:

At the end of the nineteenth century, Charles Sanders Peirce, the American philosopher, proposed and described a study that he called “semiotic” and in his *Course in General Linguistics* (1915), the Swiss Linguist, Ferdinand de Saussure, independently, proposed a science that he called “semiology”. Since then, semiotics and semiology have become alternative names for the systematic study of signs, as these function in all areas of human experience. The consideration of signs (conveyors of meaning) is not limited to explicit systems of communication such as language, the Morse code and traffic signs and signals: a great diversity of other human activities and productions – our bodily postures and gestures, the social rituals we perform, the kinds of clothes we wear, the meals we serve, the buildings we inhabit, the objects we deal with convey meanings to members who participate in a particular culture and can be analysed as signs which functions in diverse modes of signifying systems (289)

This postulation by Abrams and Harpham reinforces the Proposition of Saussure and Peirce. The contributions of these scholars (Saussure and Peirce) in the advancement of semiotics remain towering. They could be tagged as purveyors of modern semiotics.

Basically, humans use language – a complex communication system – to communicate and do other things as Nkem Okoh presents below:

To offer a different kind of summary, man employs this mystery [language] in other words, his crucial tool... to do things basically, for communicating,

imparting information, conveying command, wishes, among others communicating on feelings and emotions. For the reservation and transmission of a given culture, for phatic communion – to maintain social contract at a friendly level. For aesthetic reasons – for beauty, as in poetry and other forms of literature. For relieving tension or emotional stress (4).

Life on earth would have been miserable without a tool of communication such as language. However, communication, itself, is another term which has attracted so many scholarly attention and opinions. In all that, there seems to be a recurrent word, which is information sharing or dissemination amongst interlocutors. Humans use language to communicate, in other words, to share information, to express feelings or emotions, to build and to destroy amongst many others. Again, Okoh provides another summary of what communication is all about:

Communication is sharing, imparting, exchanging information and conveying one's ideas. It is for a purpose, it must be understood, it has a(n) (target) audience, not a one-off phenomenon, rather, a process, that is, there are elements of the communication process (8).

Broadly speaking, communication is subdivided into verbal communication (oral and written) and non-verbal communication (gestures, sign language, body language, and other paralinguistic features). The focal point is non-verbal communication which uses signs or other semiotic means to convey information from one interlocutor to another. Essential elements of the communication process include the encoder (sender), the ideal message, a channel/medium, a decoder (recipient) and the feedback. In all, communication could, only, be said to have taken place or effectively so, when all participants understood or interpret, correctly, the idea or message as encoded. Any moment there is an impediment, the process is obstructed and meaning impaired. Furthermore, the relationship between communication and signs could be linked to that of Siamese twins.

From every indication, the use of palm leaves or palm fronds has remained significant in depicting a people's religious/cultural beliefs and expectations. The chief goal of this paper is to examine the palm frond as a semiotic sign (symbol) which has invaluable communicative relevance in Iwhuruohna (Ikwerre) ethnicity of Rivers State.

In terms of migration, there is no consensus on how the people settled in their present locations. However, there are so many theories of origin surrounding the Iwhuruohna (Ikwerre) people. There is a more acceptable theory. This postulation states that the people of Iwhuruohna (Ikwerre) migrated from Benin during the reigns of Oba Ewuare (Ogwaro) before settling down at their present homelands today. The theorists traced the origin of Ikwerre to a grand ancestor – Akalaka, the ancestor of Ihuruoha (Iwhuruohna) who later gave birth to other sons who migrated and founded other Ikwerre kingdoms of today. Elder Sunday O. Amadinna in his text: “The Evolution of Ikwerre as a People” categorized Iwhuruohna into five different subgroups or kingdoms such as Ishimbam, Esila, REO, OPA and Ohaji areas (29-30). All the kingdoms and communities in the four LGAs are subsumed into one of the five groups identified by Amadinna.

While this Proposition is strictly opposed by some scholars, they proposed another theory of origin which linked Ikwerre as migrants from the Igbo nation. This is what this

researcher termed “Igbo expansionist theory”. Although through commerce, trade and marital ties, the Ikwerre people have more affinities with their Igbo neighbours. However, this does not give credence to the claims that Ikwerre people migrated from the Igbo hinterland. During the colonial era, the Igbos took advantage of regionisation as capital of Eastern Nigeria to annex all other minority ethnic groups at the time. The Aros and Nkwerre people balkanized Iwhuruohna people and imposed themselves on the aboriginés. Igbo cultural ways such as language and many others were imposed on Iwhuruohna people. The churches used Igbo Bible and sang Igbo songs on Iwhuruohna homelands.

RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

This study relies on qualitative research and ethnographic studies. There is a focus on interpreting meanings and contexts of palm fronds in cultural settings. The data got through immerse in the culture, observation and interview of community members. This is a field work experience of the researcher during years of research in his doctoral thesis.

DATA COLLECTION

The researcher as a participant observer attended some festivals, ritual sessions, dances where palm fronds were used. Interviews were conducted through talks to community members, elders and cultural practitioners. The work examines the images, or descriptions of palm fronds in use.

DATA ANALYSIS

There is a thematic analysis by identifying patterns and themes on how palm fronds are used and interpreted while semiotic analysis explores the meanings of palm fronds in different contexts.

THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

This study adopts Semiotic-Communication Theory (SCT) to evaluate this work. The SCT dives into how signs and symbols convey meaning. It considers signs and symbols such as palm fronds, words, images carry meaning beyond their initial form. However, the physical form (signifier) and the concept it represents (signified) play significant roles in this stead. Meaning is dependent on cultural context, shared codes and individual experiences (interpretation) and codes and conventions and how signs are interpreted (Palm fronds symbolise celebration in some cultures). Some influential thinkers in this theory are Ferdinand de Saussure and Charles Sanders Peirce.

PALM FRONDS AS SACRED AND SYMBOLIC OBJECTS IN GLOBAL RELIGIOUS TRADITIONS

The use of palm fronds as symbols and symbolism is as old as mankind. An author, Christopher P. Jones notes that:

The association of palm leaves with saintliness comes from feast of Palm Sunday, a celebration in Christianity commemorating Jesus entry into Jerusalem when palm branches were placed along his path. The symbolism of the palm branch in fact stretches back to the ancient world where it was a symbol of victory and peace. A victorious athlete competing in ancient Greece, for instance, was awarded a palm as a symbolic prize. The palm also has a place

in Muslim's tradition where the palm frond as a symbol of peace, is associated with humanly paradise (47).

This historian and critic – Christopher Jones – takes us back along memory lane on how useful the palm leaves have been from antiquity to Greco – Roman traditions, Jewish traditions and Islamic cultures. The palm leaves have remained as classic symbols from the beginning of human civilisations. In the Middle East and Mediterranean world, the Palm (phoenix) was sacred. In Mesopotamian religions and in Egypt, it represented immortality. In Judaism, the “Julav”, a closed frond of the date palm is a part of festival of “SUKKH”. As noted earlier, victorious athletes in ancient Greece were given a palm frond or palm tree itself. In Rome, the palm frond is a common attribute of victory personified.

In Christianity, the palm branch is associated with Jesus Triumphant Entry on Palm Sunday, when according to John's gospel, they took palm branches and went out to meet him (Jn 12:13). According to the Gospel of John 12:13: “so they took branches of palm trees and went out to meet him, and they began to shout: “Save, we pray you! Blessed is the one who comes in Jehovah's name, the King of Israel” (*New World Translation of the Holy Scriptures*). More so, the palm has a meaning representing victory, i.e. the victory of the spirit over the flesh as recorded in Revelation 7:9: “After this I saw, and look! A great crowd, which no man was able to number, out of all nations and tribes and peoples and tongues standing before the throne and before the Lamb, dressed in white robes; and there were palm branches in their hands” (*New World Translation of the Holy Scriptures*).

However, since a victory signals an end to a conflict or competition, the palm evolved into a symbol of peace, a meaning it has in Islam where it is, often, associated with paradise. The palm also appears on several flags or seats representing countries or other places with the coconut palm associated with the tropics. In Assyrian religion, the palm is one of the trees identified as the sacred tree connecting heaven, represented by the crown of the tree and earth, the base of the trunk. Beliefs from the 9th century BC show winged “genii” holding palm fronds in the presence of the sacred tree.

In Mesopotamia, the date palm may have represented fertility in humans. The Mesopotamian goddess, Inanna, who has a part in the sacred marriage ritual was believed to make dates abundant. In Ancient Egypt, palm leaves represented long life and the god “Huh” was often shown holding a palm leaf in one or both hands. The palm was carried in Egyptian funeral procession to represent eternal life.

PALM FRONDS IN AFRICAN AND NIGERIAN INDIGENOUS COMMUNICATION SYSTEM

In West Africa, Nigeria (the Kingdom of Nri in Igbo land) used the Omu - a tender palm frond to sacralise and restrain. Simon Kolawole and Emeka Umejei harp on the communicative value of palm fronds in some traditional societies in Nigeria. According to them:

The diverse forms of traditional communication in Nigeria are cultural vehicles through which members of different groups communicate with one another. And these have been helpful in fostering unity, exchange ideas, resolve

contentious issues and vexing problems and sharing information. Various forms of traditional communication have been identified in Nigeria including town criers, wooden and metal gongs, talking drum, blasts of local guns, age groups, the open market, setting fire on bushes and the palm frond. In addition, these diverse forms of traditional communication are classified as “Aroko” in Yoruba, an indigenous Yoruba semiotic device (Medialandscape.org).

The usefulness of palm frond is being under reported and evaluated. Here, the authors consider it as a vessel of traditional communication among Nigerians, especially, in the Yoruba speaking areas. This role of the palm frond is similar to all traditional societies in Nigeria. It is a semiotic device which has high communicative values. To advance the basics of their intellectualism and scholarly contributions in this regard, the duo reiterate the relevance of the palm frond as a traditional communication symbol:

Palm fronds have diverse use among different ethnic groups in Nigeria. In Yoruba traditional communication, the palm frond is considered as a “Aroko”. It is symbolically used to communicate restriction embargo or inhibition in Yoruba traditional communication. When one sees palm fronds tied to a pile or struck to the ground in a land that is being cultivated or built on, it is a symbol that there is conflict over the land. In Igbo land, it is called “Qmu”, a sacred motif. It is placed on a coffin to indicate that someone has died, and it is also a common sight in many shrines and sacred places (Medialandscape.org).

In a related development, Ambrose Ekhosuehi, in a paper entitled: “Palm Fronds (Ome) in the Culture” validated the relevance of the palm fronds as a communicative symbol among Edo people of Bini Kingdom. According to him:

The palm fronds give strong belief that keeps tradition alive in ceremonies and festivals. The ceremonies and festivals have strong community binding and add real value to the people. The leaf of a palm tree, palm frond – once when carried, is a symbol of victory, or triumph token of rejoicing in ceremonies or festivals. The palm fronds and ceremonies and festivals are used to decorate street, shrines and places to adorn sacred trees of divine worship. The palm fronds emit odours that repel evils; hence the foliage is used in masquerades. The widespread masquerades and the best known is the wooden face masks called Ekpo and Ewuwu. They protect people from spiritual disease. At an annual festival or whenever an epidemic threatens, men of middle age, the youths, don masks dressed in traditional palm fronds representing a wide range of characters and deities' beautiful faces (Edoworld.net).

The contributor harps on the beautification and communicative roles of palm frond and its rich medicinal value in a case of epidemics. Within this context, the palm frond is a potent spiritual immune booster. It wades off evil spirits and protects those adorned with it round their bodies. Although this is a contentious case, and superstitious in all ramifications, it reflects the belief system and cosmology of the people of Edo in Nigeria.

On the meaning and spiritual symbol of the palm frond, an anonymous author declares:
Palm trees hold profound spiritual meanings across different cultures. In

Christianity, palm branches symbolized Jesus entry into Jerusalem on Palm Sunday, showing victory and triumph. The Prophet Muhammed also revered palm tress, considering them a gift from Allah and a source of blessings. In both instances, palm trees embody resilience, faith and the ability to thrive even in difficult times. Each part of the palm tree carries its own symbolic meaning. The trunk, with all its tall and straight structure, symbolises strength and stability. It reminds us to stand firm in the face of adversity. The leaves or fronds of the palm tree represent peace, abundance, and victory. Their fan-like shape represents a sense of openness, welcoming optimism into our lives. Throughout history, people have used palm branches, known palm fronds to celebrate joyous occasions and make special occasions. People believe meaning palm branches brings goodluck and wards off evil spirits. They also symbolise honour and victory making them a common sight in ancient and modern celebrations (Oceanjewelrystore.com).

The palm fronds have remained very important in the affairs of humanity. The branches satisfy socio-cultural, economic, and communicative, spiritual and scholarly needs of both human and social experiences in the world.

In a related manner, Rowland Olumati engages in a study of symbology of “Qmu-ngwo” – tender palm frond in Ikwerre. According to him:

The furred young leaves of the palm tree are known as Qmu in Ikwerre language. It is an important motif among the Ikwerre. Ordinarily, it has nothing of awe or fear, attached to it. But when symbolically used as a communication medium, it attracts all the sacredness and fear that accompany such sacred items. The use of Qmu as a sacred symbol among the Ikwerre is universal. The significance of Qmu has defied rejection by both modernity and Christianity. It is always laden with spiritual messages when put into use. Qmu occupies very important position in the Ikwerre religious and social sphere. As one walks along the public and private roads, the sight of Qmu symbolically used is a common feature. Whenever, Qmu is exhibited in its symbolic use, the observer immediately decodes the information and then appreciates the metaphysical richness of Ikwerre society (224)

The palm frond (referred to as tender palm frond or Qmu) is very significant in Ikwerre just as in other African societies and the world. It covers such area as religion, culture, social and communication. The latter is our area of interest. The use of the symbol, as a means of communication, in such a way, that interlocutors understand themselves engenders effective communication. Within the purview of semiotic analysis, Qmu is considered as a symbol which in Peircean terminology is a component of a sign. The palm frond symbolises so many things in Ikwerre. Within religious arena, it is a symbol of sacredness. At traditional worship centres, it is used for decoration and evokes senses of sacredness too.

When tied round a basket, the Qmu stands for a sacrifice of propitiation. The Qmu is a symbol of communication to both living and the dead. It could communicate danger. The Qmu is used to communicate danger ahead to road user. However, Olumati observes that Qmu plays such other roles as a symbol of ethical control, a symbol of peace, a symbol of surrender, a writ of summons

among others. In a more elaborate manner, he affirms:

A man in Qmu enclosure is like one under religious ban. We could see that Qmu has a great deal of symbolic connotations and uses. It is used to communicate the presence of a sacred place or object, to set aside a sacred place or object, for peaceful settlement of any dispute and for keeping criminals in check. And more importantly, as general symbol of communication (229).

The palm frond remains a valid means of communication, which sparks off meaning and understanding among participants in the communication value chain. Whenever it is placed, it signifies more than what ordinary eyes could see. It is a conveyor of meanings. The use of symbols as ritualistic objects resides in the religions mindset or deep consciousness of the people. It is deeply seated in their minds. Again, Olumati says:

Ritual processes are a series of symbolic action which are both highly complex and multi-dimensional. They involve actors, actions use of time and space, as well as other symbolic agencies and agents. Ritual symbols is the use of concrete objects are visible emblems, ideograms, rituals, songs, prayers, myths, incantations, vows, customary behaviour are personifications (Nabofa 4). The symbolic use and significance of water, sand, oil, palm frond leaves, feathers kaolin (native white chalk) and other ritual objects is common place in Ikwerre ritual system... (18).

The palm frond is highly connotative in Ikwerre; just as in other traditional and modern societies in Nigeria. In consideration of the Peircean triadic model, the symbol is one of the components of a sign. And justifiably too, the palm frond qualifies as a symbol. It is within this perspective that this paper considers the existing literatures in the use of Qmu as a potent means of communication in Iwhuruohna ethnic nationality.

SEMIOTIC AND COMMUNICATION – THEORETICAL APPROACHES TO SYMBOLISM

From a sociological perspective on culture, the interactionists (proponents of interactionism) see culture as being created and maintained by the ways people interact and how individuals interpret each other's actions. Therefore, symbolic interactionism holds that: "every object and action have a symbolic meaning, and language serves as a means for people to represent and communicate their interpretations of these meanings to others". There is a healthy relationship or link between symbol and communication. What symbols represent act as codes of communication and this is dependent on social contract of the speech community and their acceptance in convention.

Any object, concept or word which is not limited to a single meaning could be interpreted to be a symbol. It is one of the areas or aspects of semiotic studies or semiotics. On the other hand, it could also be a literary device which uses words, people, marks, locations, abstract ideas or concepts to represent something beyond the surface meaning or initial level of meaning. Symbolism is a literary device which refers to the use of symbols in a literary production or work while a symbol is something that stands for or suggests something else.

When a sender and a receiver understand the representation of symbols used to encode a particular message or information, then communication could be said to be effective. In contrast, when interlocutors fail to understand the symbols in use, then, there is a likelihood of a break in communication (noise) or an occurrence of a miscommunication which engenders conflict, rancour, suspicion, and in more severe cases, crises, violence and war. Communication is the sharing, imparting, exchanging of information or one's ideas among people or individuals. In this paper, as stated earlier, the non-verbal type of communication is our thrust. For communication to be said to be effective, meaning must play a crucial or central role from the point of sender - idea/message – channel/media-receiver (decoder). If by any eventuality that meaning is thwarted or obstructed, this will amount to miscommunication. When interlocutors understand the encoded message as intended, then, communication is said to be effective (Okoh 9, Ndimele 2-5, Agava I).

There is also symbolic communication which is viewed as the exchange of messages that change expectations of events through technology, and exchange of information amongst animals. In humans, symbolic communication can be defined as the rule-governing use of a system or arbitrary symbols whose definition and usage are agreed upon by the community of users. Here, symbols are considered the signifier that represents meaning (the signified). It is instructive to note that only auditory speech, words, and characters in printed visual forms, physical objects, fashion and clothing can be classified as symbols. However, any entity, natural or social, physical or mental, tangible or intangible, can be a symbol if it can be employed to represent something else (Wikipedia.org).

Again, modern symbolic communication is divided into verbal symbolic communication and non-verbal communication. The former refers to communication that makes use of words, both spoken and written. Saussure introduced the notion of there being no inherent notion between the use of cow in English and “vache” in French to signify the same mental concept. Nonverbal symbolic communication uses learned, socially shared signal system. As with verbal symbolic communication, the relation between a sign and what it signifies is arbitrary. This is the domain of symbol because it is arbitrary, as a subset of a sign, and its meaning is derivable from conventions of the users of any language (Wikipedia.org).

Symbols remain one of the most important elements of any language since they serve to communicate without a need of verbal response. This happens because it is immediately recognised and the one who has, as a public observes it, must know its meaning to understand what it refers to. The symbol is an important element of communication between human beings. When we talk about communication, we are referring to the fact whereby two people exchange ideas or thoughts, but for that to be achieved, both people involved in the act of communication must understand what each of the words or terms that are used refer to, show more content and therefore based on the representation of something using something else in. Symbols could be considered as a sign of another sign, since it is through them that they are constructed and expressed (www.ipl.org).

Onyemaechi Udumukwu lends his voice to the communicative role of symbols as a sign. In his opinion:

Signification in symbol is realized through conventional relationship that is the relationship between the signified and the signifier is highly arbitrary in nature because it required a cultural context for its actualization. In other words, the red card... requires the status of a symbol because of the professional context of the game of football. Outside that defined conventional setting, it is a mere sheet of paper. In the incident involving Okonkwo, his gun and the death of his cousin, we are dealing with one sign, an index. But the sign has generated a third and for the sign which can be explained at the level of the symbol (134).

This literary critic and scholar gives us more insights in what constitutes a semiotic symbol and how meanings are deduced therein. Symbols communicate effectively in every sphere of human and social experiences. Within the context of a playing field, the red card invokes rules and punishments as well as when issued against any player within fields of plays, while the yellow card is just a mere warning to avoid a strict discipline in the case of a red card. Within the context of football, Paul Cobley and Lisa Jansz, aptly, explain this on the nature of a symbol. According to them:

A football referee shows a red card to a football player who has committed a blatant professional foul. As the red card invokes rules (professional fouls are illegal and lead to penalties against the perpetrator). It is also symbolic (the red card signifies the professional foul by convention)... (*Introducing Semiotics* in Udumukwu 134).

Semiotic signs as symbols refer to something else other than itself and advance meaning and communication. Any player who is issued a red card, immediately, understands the weight of his punishment for violating the rules of engagement within the field of play and the specified time of action.

Figure 2: René Magritte's *The Treachery of Images*



The Magritte's image can be translated as "Treason of Images" and when one reads the quote above, you can probably tell Magritte is talking about this painting – sign. The inscription of French translates to: "This is not a pipe" and Magritte is correct. What we see is not a pipe but a digital image of a photograph of a painting of a pipe. It is not a pipe. However, if you are convinced that it is one, then, fill it with tobacco, light it and smoke. This is another classic

demonstration of what signs – icons, indexes and symbols (images) represent or portray in the communication value chain.

In this sense and context, symbols act as veritable tools for communication and an effective one at that when interlocutors interpret correctly or most appropriately the meaning of the symbols in focus. Context, shared knowledge and assumptions play crucial roles in communication, as they influence how, effectively, messages are conveyed and understood. This includes physical, social, cultural and temporal factors. Contexts disambiguate meaning and provide a framework for interpretation. Shared knowledge refers to the common understanding, experiences and information shared between communicators or interlocutors. This enables communicators to use short cuts, jargon and implicit references. They facilitate more efficient and effective communication.

Assumptions refer to implicit beliefs, expectations and presumptions held by communicators or interlocutors. These can be based on shared knowledge, context or individual experiences. They can either facilitate or hinder communication depending on whether they are accurate or not. The interplay between context, shared knowledge and assumption can facilitate understanding – when context, shared knowledge and assumption align, communication is more effective, create misunderstandings – when there is a mismatch, misinterpretation can occur, influence interpretation – context, shared knowledge and assumptions can shape how messages are interpreted. To improve communication, it is important to consider clarifying context and shared knowledge avoiding assumptions or making them explicit, verifying understanding through feedback and being aware of cultural and individual differences in context, shared knowledge and assumptions.

Context-dependence in symbols and communication refers to the idea that the meaning of a symbol, word or message depends on the context in which it is used. This means that the same symbol or message have different meanings in different situations, cultures or environment. There are types of context-dependence such as semantic context – the meaning of a word or symbol depends on the surrounding words or symbols. Syntactic context – the meaning of a sentence depends on its grammatical structure. Pragmatic context – the meaning of a symbol or message depends on the speaker's intention, tone and audience.

Culture context – the meaning of a symbol or message depends on cultural norms, values and beliefs. Situation context – the meaning of a message depends on the physical or social environment. Context – dependence has implications in the following areas: communication accuracy – without shared context, messages can be misinterpreted, symbolic meaning – symbols can have multiple meanings depending on context, language understanding – context is crucial for understanding language, intercultural communication – contextual differences can lead to misunderstandings across cultures, artificial intelligence – context dependence challenges AI systems to accurately interpret human communication.

To overcome context – dependence challenges, we consider the following: providing clear context – establish a shared understanding of the situation or environment, using explicit language – avoid ambiguity by using specific and clear language, considering cultural differences – being aware of cultural nuances and adapt communication, accordingly, verifying

understanding – conforming that the intended meaning is conveyed and understood. All these empower communicators and interlocutors to improve communication effectiveness and avoid misunderstanding (Source: Meta AI)

However, multiple interpretations in symbols and communication refer to the phenomenon where a simple symbol, message or a sign can be understood in different ways by various individuals or groups. This occurs due to ambiguity – symbols or messages with multiple possible meanings, contextual dependence – meaning depends in the situation or environment, cultural differences symbols or messages interpreted, differently across cultures, personal experiences – individual's unique experience influence their interpretation, semantic complexity – symbols or messages with complex nuanced meaning.

CULTURAL AND SEMIOTIC CONTEXT OF PALM FRONDS IN IWHURUOHNA

Palm Fronds in Iwhuruohna (Ikwerre) of Rivers State from a field work survey, this researcher has identified some places or contexts in Iwhuruohna communities where palm fronds are used for one purpose or another. Such areas are: disputed land, traditional rites/cultural festivals, worship centres (traditional and orthodox), writ of summons/litigations, communication symbols, masquerade displays, cultural decorations/costumes among others.

The meanings or significations of palm fronds in these contexts are varied. What the palm signifies in context A is quite different from its signification in Context B and so on. For convenience, this paper shall, randomly, select some areas where palm fronds are used among Iwhuruohna people and exhaustively evaluate them, to an extent where our knowledge would be enriched for scholarly purposes.

ANALYSIS OF PALM FRONDS AS COMMUNICATIVE SYMBOLS

Palm Fronds in Masquerade Displays

Figure 3: Eze Ekpo of Alimini Isiokpo (7)

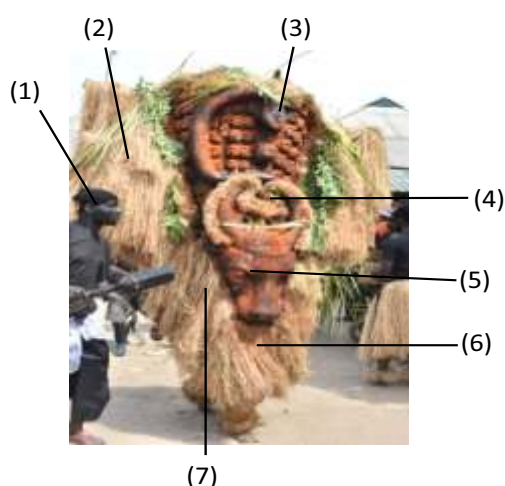
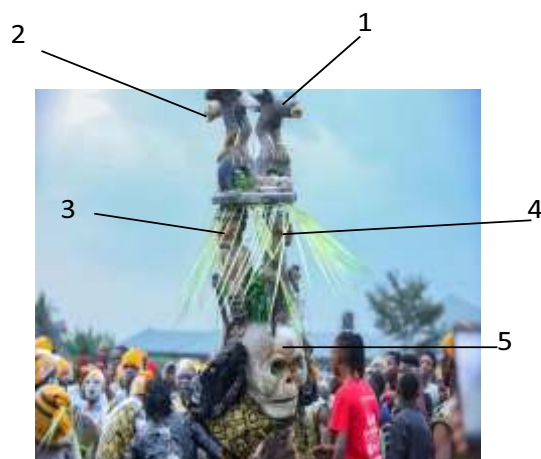


Figure 4: A Mask of the Warriors' Dance Group



- 1.Head gear
- 2.Cocks
- 3.Head of ancestors
- 4.Lion head
- 5.Animal head
- 6.Raffia material
- 7.Oji or ebi

- 1.A bee
- 2.A bee
- 3.Human statute (ancestor)
- 4.Human statute (ancestor)
- 5.A carved bee head / human skull

Palm fronds in masquerade displays represent protection, blessings or ancestral presence. They are part of the masquerade's costume or headdress. The palm fronds create a festive or sacred atmosphere. They could symbolize specific themes or messages in the performance of the masquerades. The fronds add a natural, vibrant element to costumes and decorations enhancing visual impact of the masquerade. As a part of the traditional rituals, the palm fronds signify a connection to heritage and community.

Palm Fronds in a New Yam Festival (Hajoku Omerelu)

Figure 5: Sacred Yams of Ihu Nkwa
Hajoku Omerelu



- 1.Members of Eriji Dance Group
- 2.White cloth tied round the basket (Opa)
- 3.Feathers
- 4.Sacred yams
- 5.Spectators

Figure 6: Authorized Venue for Hajoku Cultural Festival



- 1.Shade
- 2.Blocks
- 3.Animal horn
- 4.Palm fronds
- 5.Entertainment objects (Palm wine and kola nuts)
- 6.Adherents

Figure 7: Erinshi Performers

- (1)Coconut tree
- (2)Members of Erinshi
- (3)A dancer of Erinshi
- (4) Kid spectators



The palm fronds symbolise fertility, prosperity and celebration. They are, often, used to bless and purify the new yams, ensuring a bountiful harvest. Within the context of ritual use, they are, often, used to bless and purify the new yams, ensuring a bountiful harvest. Within the context of ritual use, they are used to decorate altars, pathways or festival grounds by creating a festive atmosphere.

During new yam festivals as in Hajoku Omerelu, the palm fronds are used to decorate the festival grounds or yam altars. They form a part of the traditional rituals or processions. The palm fronds also symbolise the community's gratitude and joy.

Palm Fronds in Ogbuishiehi Festival of Elele (Rites of Passage)

Figure 8: Owhor holder, Elder Eta administering an Oath

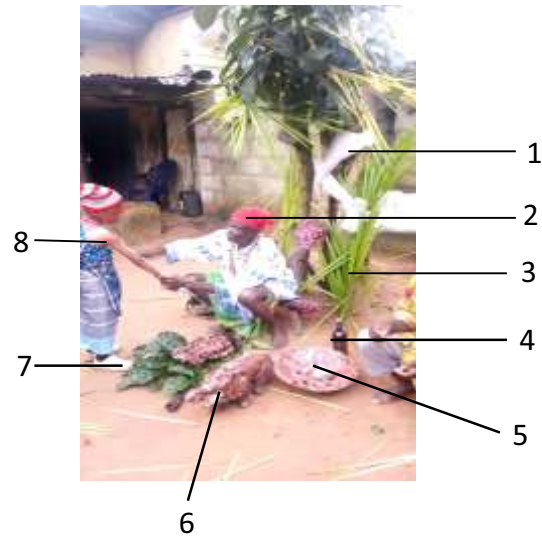


Figure 9: An adherent of Elele Culture and Tradition



1. White cloth
2. Elder Eta, Owhor holder
3. Palm fronds
4. A bottle of locally brewed gin
5. Kaolin, kolanuts, alligator, etc
6. Effigy of an elephant (Ehie)
7. White stockers
8. Blessing ChizalamAkpenchi

Figure 10: Celebration of Ishi Ehi rites of Passage



- (1) Sampson Elechi
- (2) Ohna Dagogo Elechi
- (3) Iheanyichukwu Wodah
- (4) Ezebunwo Elechi

- (1) Sampson Elechi
- (2) Ali Enyidah
- (3) Ishi ehi
- (4) Achalu (bangle)
- (5) Wristwatch

Figure 11: Initiates of Ogba/Otutu Anya

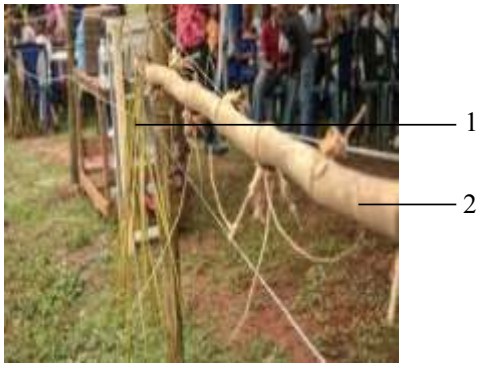


- (1) Kingsley Ola Wosu (Ozuaha)
- (2) Promise Wali (Omademe)
- (3) Simeon Amadi-Wali (Omademe)

In this circumstance, the palm fronds symbolise transition, growth and spiritual connection. In rites of passage as in “Ogbuishiehi”, the palm fronds signify transition to adulthood or new status, protection and blessings for the initiates. They connect the ancestors to the tradition. The palm fronds decorate pathways or ritual spaces to create symbolic barriers or boundaries. They purify or bless the initiates. They are tied to community and tradition and emphasize the importance of cultural heritages. Again, they mark initiation ceremonies, marriage rituals and transition or coming-of-age ceremonies.

Palm Fronds in Oboni Dance Performances

Figure 12: Stage for Oboni Performance



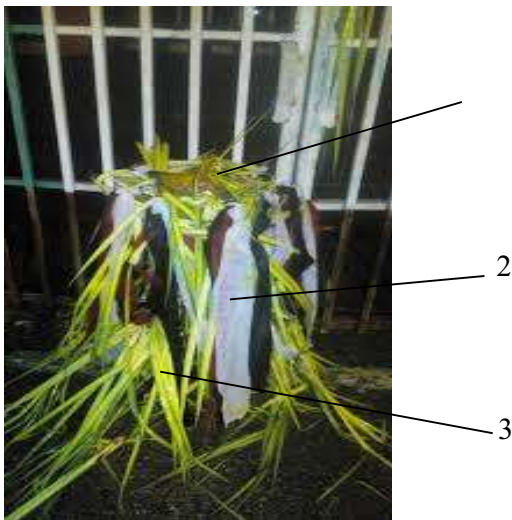
- 1. Bamboo
- 2. Palm fronds

Figure 13: Bare body Performer of Oboni dance



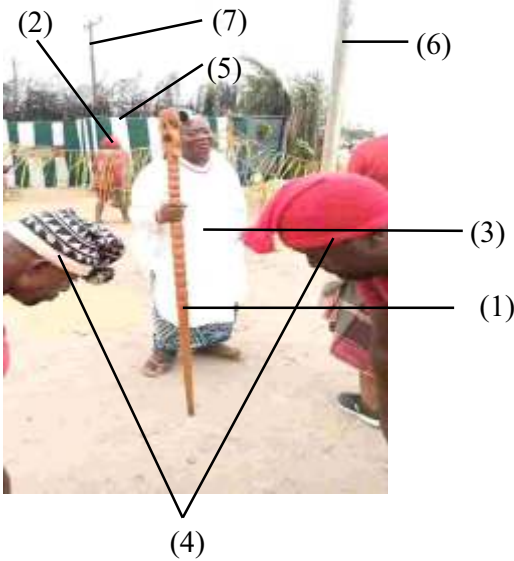
- (1) Oboni pot
- (2) An initiate carrying Oboni pot

Figure 14: Eseni Drum of Oboni



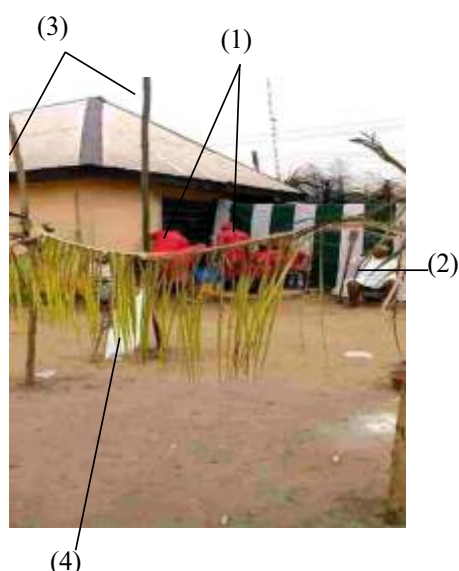
- 1.Eseni Drum
- 2.White material
- 3.Palm fronds

Figure 15: Staff of Authority



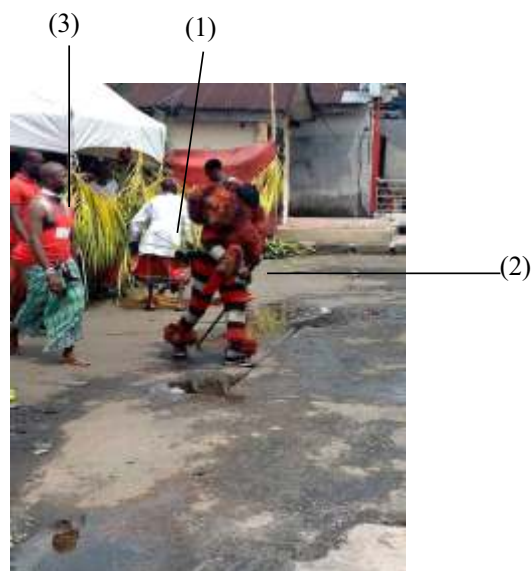
- (1)A staff of authority
- (2)Oboni dancers
- (3)Eze Oboni
- (4)Elders' cottage
- (5)Innermost cottage
- (6)Electric pole
- (7)Electric pole

Figure 16: Oboni Dance Stage



- (1) Initiates of Oboni
- (2) Eze Oboni
- (3) Standing bamboo trees
- (4) Oboni pot

Figure 17: The Masquerade



- 1. Eze Oboni
- 2. Ogbunmanigwe mask
- 3. Initiates of Oboni

In cultural dances such as in “Oboni” of Iwhuruohna ethnic nationality, palm fronds add flair to the dance. They symbolise celebration, joy and continuity. In the dance, they represent connection to nature and tradition, spiritual expression or invocation, festivity and communal bounding. The dances use palm fronds to enhance movements or gestures, create rhythmic sounds or visuals, depicts stories or themes. In terms of aesthetics, palm fronds add colour, texture and movement to costumes or props. In Nigerian cultural dances as in “Oboni”, palm fronds feature in festival performances, traditional ceremonies and story-telling dances.

Conclusion

Life on earth would have remained meaningless and hollow without any instruments of communication such as language. Language, itself, is a complex system of communication which uses shared signs and symbols among interlocutors to express their feelings, emotions, interact and pass on information from one person to another. However, communication is language in action. There is a symbiotic relationship between language and communication. Semiotic symbols act as catalysts in driving this aspect of language through nonverbal means of expression. As noted elsewhere in this paper, signs, signaling systems (symbols) are conveyors of meanings via visual images or expressions without necessarily vocalising through spoken or written means (communications).

Every sign, mark, word, concept or ideas that are tangible within a speech community could be considered as a symbol when such objects share some level of arbitrariness and conventionality in their expression of meanings which advance communication amongst interlocutors in a communication value chain.

In our everyday experiences in life, maps are considered as iconic signs because there is a resemblance between the signifier and the signified. The maps enable us to understand territorial terrains of the geographical locations they represent. However, there is another relationship built on a natural principle of cause and effect. If this, then, there must be that! A classic example is the common 'no smoke without fire' experience. The arbitrariness and conventionality blend within a cultural context or social experience is what semiotic symbol underpins. It is, within this purview, that palm frond as a symbol, is considered and evaluated in Iwhuruohna. The whole essence of this experiment is to evaluate the possible interpretations of palm fronds as used in different contexts in Iwhuruohna as a distinct ethnic group in Rivers State and Nigeria.

CONTRIBUTION TO KNOWLEDGE/SCHOLARSHIP

This study reveals cultural symbolism by uncovering how palm fronds convey meanings in specific cultural contexts. It could enhance understanding of non-verbal communication by highlighting the role of natural elements in conveying messages. This study informs cultural expression and identity and shows how communities use palm fronds to communicate values, traditions and emotions. It contributes to such other fields as cultural studies, communication studies and anthropology.

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